US weighs $200,000 fine on Spanish vessels following Israel cargo ban

送信者: POLITICO Pro Mobility 受信日時: 2026-10-15 04:30

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By Stefanie Bolzen · Oct 14, 2026, 9:29 PM · View in your browser

The Trump administration is considering a six-figure fine on Spanish-flagged ships after finding “conclusive evidence that Spain denied U.S.-flagged vessels access to its ports.” According to the U.S. Federal Maritime Commission, Madrid has created unfavorable shipping conditions and thereby impeded foreign trade.

The agency, which regulates U.S. international ocean transportation system, is now considering two sets of remedies: a future fee of $200,000 for Spanish ships entering U.S. ports or restrictions on the import of Spanish goods such as perfumery and cosmetics, oils and fats, ceramics, articles of stone, and sugar and confectionaries, according to a notice published Wednesday . Either would be a significant blow to Spanish businesses.

The trade investigation stems back nearly two years and comes at a time of continued tensions between Spain and President Donald Trump. Trump has repeatedly threatened the Socialist government of Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez with trade sanctions because of Spain’s unwillingness to pay the NATO defense target of 5% of GDP.

The latest trade spat between Washington and Madrid is also rooted in politics. At the end of 2024, the Spanish port of Algeciras barred U.S. vessels from entering because they were reportedly transporting military goods towards Israel. Madrid had previously imposed a ban on military shipments to Israel, after pressure from lawmakers in Sánchez’ parliamentary group and pro-Palestinian lobbyists.

The FMC investigation found that Madrid’s actions damaged “the efficiency and reliability of the international ocean shipping supply chain.” The Commission said the move has also hindered the promotion and development of U.S. exports, as much as national security needs.

The agency on Wednesday also opened a public comment period on its proposed remedies, which will allow stakeholders to submit their concerns. Once that process concludes, the Spanish government will be invited to participate in a hearing, the FMC said.

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